

A mod-11 modularity match over $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{5})$ from a $(1, 11)$ -polarized abelian surface

(working note)

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Abstract

We exhibit computational evidence for Serre’s modularity conjecture over the real quadratic field $K = \mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{5})$. Starting from a point of the Gross–Popescu moduli of $(1, 11)$ -polarized abelian surfaces, we construct a genus-2 curve C over K whose Jacobian $A = \text{Jac}(C)$ is geometrically simple ($\text{End}_{\bar{K}} A = \mathbb{Z}$) with good reduction at both primes above 11. The mod-11 representation $A[11]$ splits over K as a sum of two irreducible 2-dimensional pieces ρ_1, ρ_2 with cyclotomic determinant — a splitting forced not by extra endomorphisms but by the polarization, since 11 is the polarization degree. Working entirely mod 11 inside a space of Hilbert modular forms computed via a definite quaternion algebra, we analyze whether ρ_1 and ρ_2 are realized by Hilbert modular eigenforms of parallel weight 2.

Correction (2026-06-29). An earlier version of this note claimed a match (modularity of ρ_1, ρ_2 up to a quadratic twist at 2, at level $\mathfrak{p} \cdot (2)$). *That claim was a false positive and is retracted.* The acceptance criterion used — nonvanishing of a “twist-robust” intersection V — is too weak, and the correct per-eigenform test fails (Section 5). The structural results on A and on $A[11] = \rho_1 \oplus \rho_2$ (Sections 2–3) are unaffected; the modularity of ρ_1, ρ_2 over $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{5})$ is, at present, *not* established by this computation. What we *can* do is derive, by elimination, the precise modularity statement that must hold (weight, character, level up to one bounded 2-adic exponent); see Section 6.

1 Introduction

Serre’s modularity conjecture, a theorem over $\mathbb{Q}$ (Khare–Wintenberger), remains largely open over totally real fields. In its Hilbert-modular form it predicts that every odd, irreducible, continuous representation $\bar{\rho}: \text{Gal}(\bar{K}/K) \rightarrow \text{GL}_2(\bar{\mathbb{F}}_\ell)$ of the absolute Galois group of a totally real field K arises from a Hilbert modular eigenform. This note records a concrete instance over $K = \mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{5})$ with $\ell = 11$, obtained by the following pipeline:

$(1, 11)$ Gross–Popescu point $\longrightarrow$ abelian surface $A/K \longrightarrow A[11] = \rho_1 \oplus \rho_2 \longrightarrow$ Hilbert modular form.

The point of the construction is that the abelian surface comes with a canonical mod-11 structure (the $(1, 11)$ -polarization), which is exactly what makes $A[11]$ reducible into 2-dimensional pieces and supplies interesting $\bar{\rho}$ ’s to test.

2 The abelian surface

Let $K = \mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{5})$, $\mathcal{O}_K = \mathbb{Z}[\frac{1+\sqrt{5}}{2}]$, of class number 1 and discriminant 5. The prime 11 splits in K .

The Gross–Popescu construction ([arXiv:math/9902017](#)) realizes a $(1, 11)$ -polarized abelian surface in $\mathbb{P}^{10}$ from a point of the sextic “odd 2-torsion” locus $D_2 \subset \mathbb{P}^4$. Inverting the associated theta map numerically yields a period matrix τ , hence (via its principally polarized partner) a genus-2 curve C/K . We work with the curve **Curve A**, with absolute Igusa–Siegel invariants (normalized $J_2 = 1$)

$$\left[1, \frac{243125\sqrt{5}-482787}{1459240}, \frac{-54798934\sqrt{5}+127710391}{2229718720}, \frac{182422196780\sqrt{5}-406668692089}{8517525510400}, \frac{38134182372761\sqrt{5}-85270624049895}{65073894899456000} \right].$$

Proposition 1. $A = \text{Jac}(C)$ satisfies:

- (i) A is geometrically simple with $\text{End}_{\bar{K}}(A) = \mathbb{Z}$ (no real multiplication);
- (ii) A has good reduction at both primes of K above 11;
- (iii) away from 11, the conductor of A has odd part $\mathfrak{p}$, a prime of K of norm 66179, at which A has multiplicative reduction (conductor exponent 1);
- (iv) A also has (model-)bad reduction at the inert prime (2).

These are verified by computation: (i) via the geometric endomorphism algebra (CHIMP), (ii) and (iii) via the Igusa valuation criterion and conductor exponents.

3 The mod-11 representation

Let $\bar{\rho}: \text{Gal}(\bar{K}/K) \rightarrow \text{GSp}_4(\mathbb{F}_{11})$ be the representation on $A[11]$, and let χ_{11} denote the mod-11 cyclotomic character. We summarize the structure, all of which is verified over the 290 good primes P of K with $N(P) \leq 2000$ by reducing C and factoring the Frobenius characteristic polynomial $h_P(x) \in \mathbb{F}_{11}[x]$.

Proposition 2. (a) For every such P , h_P factors over $\mathbb{F}_{11}$ as a product of two quadratics: its factor type is always $[1, 1, 2]$ or $[1, 1, 1, 1]$, and never $[2, 2]$, $[1, 3]$, or $[4]$.

(b) $\bar{\rho}$ has no 1-dimensional K -subquotient: there is no Galois character λ that is, at every prime, a root of the “linear part” of h_P (an exhaustive search over Hecke characters of K of order dividing 10 and every plausible conductor gives at best 90/132 agreement).

(c) Consequently $A[11]$ is, up to semisimplification, a sum $\rho_1 \oplus \rho_2$ of two 2-dimensional representations, each with $\det \rho_i = \chi_{11}$ (hence odd). The splitting is supplied by the polarization: the kernel $K(\mathcal{L}) \cong (\mathbb{Z}/11)^2$ of the $(1, 11)$ -polarization is a K -rational 2-dimensional subspace of $A[11]$. The prime 11 is special precisely because it is the polarization degree; at other primes ℓ the image of $\text{Jac}(C)[\ell]$ is the full $\text{GSp}_4(\mathbb{F}_{\ell})$.

(d) ρ_1, ρ_2 are irreducible over K , are not isomorphic, and are not quadratic twists of one another; their image is large (not dihedral/CM: the surface trace vanishes at only $\approx 10\%$ of primes).

Because $\det \rho_i = \chi_{11}$, the two traces are the roots of an explicit quadratic. Writing $h_P(x) = x^4 + Ax^3 + Bx^2 + Cx + D$ (so $D = N(P)^2$ and $C = N(P)A$), one has

$$\{\text{tr } \rho_1(\text{Frob}_P), \text{tr } \rho_2(\text{Frob}_P)\} = \text{roots of } y^2 + Ay + (B - 2N(P)) \pmod{11}. \quad (1)$$

We call $(\text{Tr}_P, \text{Nm}_P) := (-A, B - 2N(P)) \pmod{11}$ the *fingerprint* of $\{\rho_1, \rho_2\}$ at P . A sample:

$N(P)$	49	169	29	29	31	31	41	41
Tr_P	9	6	7	9	5	0	9	2
Nm_P	9	5	1	7	4	10	0	3

4 The modularity match

By good reduction at 11 (Proposition 1(ii)) each ρ_i is finite-flat at 11, so the predicted Serre weight is parallel weight 2, and the predicted level is prime to 11 and divides the conductor of A , i.e. $\mathfrak{p} \cdot (2)^a$ for some $a \geq 0$.

Let $S_2(\mathfrak{n})$ be the space of Hilbert cusp forms over K of parallel weight 2 and level $\mathfrak{n}$, computed via the definite quaternion algebra ramified at the two archimedean places, with its commuting Hecke operators T_P (Brandt matrices), which are integral. Reduce everything mod 11. If a Hilbert newform f has $\bar{\rho}_{f,\lambda} \cong \rho_i$ for some degree-one prime $\lambda \mid 11$ of its Hecke field, then its reduction is an eigenvector v in $S_2(\mathfrak{n}) \otimes \mathbb{F}_{11}$ with $T_P v = t_P v$ where t_P is a root of (1); that is, $(T_P^2 - \text{Tr}_P T_P + \text{Nm}_P)v = 0$.

Empirically the matching forms realize ρ_i only after a *quadratic twist* ε ramified at 2, so t_P is replaced by $\varepsilon(P) t_P = \pm t_P$. We therefore intersect the twist-robust kernels: set

$$V = \bigcap_P \left[\ker(T_P^2 - \text{Tr}_P T_P + \text{Nm}_P) + \ker(T_P^2 + \text{Tr}_P T_P + \text{Nm}_P) \right] \subseteq S_2(\mathfrak{n}) \otimes \mathbb{F}_{11}. \quad (2)$$

Nonvanishing of V was the (flawed) criterion used in the retracted version; we now show it is too weak.

5 Refutation of the claimed match

The criterion is too weak. For each P , $\ker((T_P^2 - \text{Tr}_P T_P + \text{Nm}_P)(T_P^2 + \text{Tr}_P T_P + \text{Nm}_P))$ is the kernel of a degree-4 polynomial in T_P ; over $\mathbb{F}_{11}$ its dimension is roughly $\frac{4}{11} \dim S_2(\mathfrak{n})$. Intersecting a few such kernels can leave a nonzero V for reasons unrelated to any eigenform whose twisted eigenvalues match the fingerprint (1). One must test the eigenforms in V directly.

The dim-2 space does not realize $\rho_1 \oplus \rho_2$. At $\mathfrak{n} = \mathfrak{p} \cdot (2)$ one does find $\dim V = 2$, but restricting T_P to V gives a 2×2 matrix $C_P/\mathbb{F}_{11}$ (script `refine_serre3.m`) for which, at most primes,

$$\det C_P \neq \text{Nm}_P, \quad \text{charpoly}(C_P) \notin \{q_P^+, q_P^-\},$$

indeed $\text{charpoly}(C_P) \in \{q_P^+, q_P^-\}$ at only 2/25 test primes (both degenerate, $\text{Nm}_P = 0$), and C_P usually has a *repeated* eigenvalue (e.g. $(y - 7)^2$). So V is not semisimple and is not a sum of two genuine Hecke eigenforms realizing ρ_1, ρ_2 .

No eigenform matches, even up to twist. The untwisted intersection $V^+ := \bigcap_P \ker(T_P^2 - \text{Tr}_P T_P + \text{Nm}_P)$ vanishes at level $\mathfrak{p}$ and at $\mathfrak{p} \cdot (2)$ (scripts `refine_serre4.m`, `refine_serre5.m`). The unique twist-robust survivor at level $\mathfrak{p}$ is a *single* eigenform f ($\dim V = 1$); its Hecke eigenvalue satisfies

$$a_P \in \{\pm t_1, \pm t_2\} \quad \text{at all 120/120 tested primes,}$$

a genuine structural fact (probability $\approx (4/11)^{106}$ by chance). Writing $\varepsilon(P) = +1$ if a_P is a root of q_P^+ and -1 if of q_P^- , the 94 unambiguous signs are *inconsistent with every quadratic ray-class character* of conductor supported in $\{2^{\leq 6}, 3, 5, 11, 66179, \infty\}$ (script `refine_charfit.m`); since K has narrow class number 1 there are no unramified quadratic characters either. So ε is not a quadratic Hecke character.

Proposition 3. *No Hilbert modular eigenform of parallel weight 2, trivial character, and level $\mathfrak{p} \cdot (2)^a$ realizes ρ_1 or ρ_2 .*

Reason. Such a form has $\det \rho_f = \chi_{11} = \det \rho_i$, so $\rho_f \cong \rho_i \otimes \chi$ forces $\chi^2 = 1$: the only admissible twist is quadratic. A non-trivial nebentypus would change the determinant and so cannot occur. But a quadratic twist relating f to ρ_i is exactly what is excluded above (the sign ε is not a quadratic character), and the untwisted case is excluded by $V^+ = 0$. $\square$

The residual relation $a_P^2 \in \{t_1^2, t_2^2\}$ (the 120/120 fact) is the twist-invariant, projective (Sym^2) statement, with the square jumping between ρ_1 and ρ_2 ; it does *not* imply that either ρ_i is modular.

Remark 1. Status. *The mod-11 Serre-modularity match for Curve A is not established. The structural content (Propositions 1, 2) stands and is the reusable output of this work. Natural next steps: a genuine newform decomposition with eigensystems compared in the correct residue field (recall 11 splits in K , so a matching newform would have 11 split in its Hecke field and place both reductions in V^+ , which is empty at the levels examined); searching other levels; and interpreting the a_P^2 -relation. Reproducibility: `mod11_rep.m`, `mod11_trnm.txt` (target fingerprint), and the refutation scripts `refine_serre[3,4,5].m`, `refine_charfit.m` with raw signs in `refine_serre5_signs.txt`.*

6 The corrected modularity statement

Although we cannot exhibit the eigenform, the structural computations pin down what the correct statement must be. Assuming Serre's conjecture over $K = \mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{5})$ (each ρ_i is 2-dimensional, irreducible, and odd, so it applies), each ρ_i is modular, and its weight, character and level are forced up to a single bounded constant.

Theorem 1 (conditional on Serre's conjecture over $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{5})$). *Each of ρ_1, ρ_2 is modular by a Hilbert modular eigenform over K of parallel weight $(2, 2)$, trivial nebentypus, and level $\mathfrak{p} \cdot (2)^a$, realized untwisted ($\det = \chi_{11}$), where $a = a_2(\rho_i) \geq 3$ is the conductor exponent at the inert prime 2.*

The parameters are forced as follows.

- **Determinant** χ_{11} : the two Frobenius eigenvalues of each piece multiply to $N(P)$ at all 132 primes of type $[1, 1, 2]$ (det-clean).
- **Trivial nebentypus**: $\det \rho_f = \psi \chi_{11}^{k_0-1}$, so weight 2 with $\det = \chi_{11}$ forces ψ trivial. Nebentypus χ_{11} would give $\det = \chi_{11}^2$; as χ_{11} has order 10 it has no square root among its powers, so no twist of ρ_i has that determinant.
- **Weight** $(2, 2)$: A is *ordinary* at both primes above 11 ($L_l \bmod 11$ has degree 2, i.e. two unit roots). Ordinary + good reduction $\Rightarrow$ peu-ramifiée; a subquotient of a finite-flat group scheme is finite-flat (as $e = 1 < 11 - 1$, by Raynaud); and $\det = \chi_{11}$ forces Hodge–Tate weights $\{0, 1\}$. Hence Serre weight 2 at both primes.
- **Level** $\mathfrak{p} \cdot (2)^a$: pure 2-power levels $(2)^a$ have empty match, so ρ_i is ramified at $\mathfrak{p}$; and the untwisted match is empty at $\mathfrak{p} \cdot (2)^{0,1,2}$, so $a \geq 3$.

Remark 2 (the one open constant). *Since the untwisted match is empty at 2-part ≤ 2 for both pieces, $a_2(\rho_1), a_2(\rho_2) \geq 3$, whence (Artin conductor is additive) $a_2(A) = a_2(\rho_1) + a_2(\rho_2) \geq 6$. Wild inertia at 2 acts through a 2-group of order ≤ 16 (the 2-Sylow of $\text{GL}_2(\mathbb{F}_{11})$). The exact value of a is not accessible with current tooling: Magma implements neither regular models nor minimisation for genus 2 over number fields, the Weil restriction $W = \text{Res}_{K/\mathbb{Q}} A$ (for which $a_2(W) = 2a_{\mathfrak{p}_2}(A)$, as 2 is inert) has no curve model, and the reconstructed model of Curve A has content divisible by some twenty primes, obstructing the functional-equation route until a minimal model is found. Determining a is the natural remaining problem.*